The Life That Continues: Sarah's Particular Dominion, the Name of the Parsha, and Covenantal Non-Domination

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Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

Likkutei Sichos Volume 15, Chayei Sarah A — An Expanded and Extended Reflection
Dedicated l'ilui nishmat the Rebbetzin Sarah Shifra a"h
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Introduction: The Name as the Key

The name of a parsha is not decorative. In the Rebbe's reading it is the key that unlocks the entire content. When a portion opens with the words "And Sarah died" (Bereishis 23:2) and then records the purchase of a burial site, the securing of a marriage for Yitzchak, the distribution of inheritance, and the burial of Avraham, the question is immediate: why is this parsha still called *Chayei Sarah*—the Life of Sarah? The answer developed in Likkutei Sichos Volume 15, Chayei Sarah A is that true life is not the span of years measured by the body but the enduring influence that continues after the body has returned to the earth. The events that follow Sarah's death are not a departure from her life; they are its revelation and completion. They show, in concrete narrative form, the particular work that was uniquely hers.

That work is the establishment of a focused inheritance. The notes from the shiur capture the contrast with the English anchors "Father Abraham" and "Listen to Sarah." Avraham is *av hamon goyim* (Bereishis 17:5), father of a multitude of nations. His chesed is expansive. It reaches outward. It is reluctant to close the circle. When the question of Yishmael arises, Avraham is troubled by the demand that the son of the maidservant be sent away. Sarah is not. She insists that the inheritance belong exclusively to Yitzchak: "the son of this maidservant shall not inherit with my son, with Yitzchak" (Bereishis 21:10). Hashem's instruction to Avraham is unambiguous: "Listen to Sarah" (Bereishis 21:12). The name Sarah itself is linked to *serarah*—dominion. Her role is not to expand the circle indefinitely but to guard it so that it remains the circle of Am Yisrael.

This contrast reaches beyond the household. It is the structural principle of the covenant as it is transmitted. Avraham's universal orientation remains real and necessary. The nations are not erased. Yet the actual inheritance of the Land and the line of the covenant passes through Yitzchak alone. The events after Sarah's death demonstrate that this particular transmission continues even when she is no longer present in the body.

The Post-Death Narrative as Continuation of Life

The purchase of Me'arat HaMachpelah is not a local real-estate transaction. It is the securing of a permanent burial place for the matriarch and, by extension, for the fathers who will follow. Avraham insists on paying full price rather than accepting the cave as a gift (Bereishis 23:16). The Midrash notes that three parcels of land cannot be disputed by the nations: Me'arat HaMachpelah, Kever Yosef, and Har HaBayit. The search for Yitzchak's wife is restricted to Avraham's own family; local matches and Eliezer's daughter are rejected because "my son is blessed and you are cursed." The full inheritance is given to Yitzchak; the children of the concubines receive gifts and are sent away (Bereishis 25:5–6). The Torah stresses that Yishmael is "the son of Hagar the Egyptian, Sarah's maidservant" (Bereishis 25:12). Even the later scene at Avraham's burial records Yishmael placing Yitzchak first, an acknowledgment that the exclusive line is the line of Sarah. These acts are the ongoing expression of her *serarah*.

The footnotes of the sicha anchor this reading in the classic sources. Rashi on Bereishis 23:1 and the Midrash (Bereishis Rabbah 58:1) on the years of Sarah being "all equal for good" establish that the name itself points to a completeness that is not exhausted by the years of her physical life. The return of the three signs when Rivka enters the tent (Bereishis 24:67; Rashi; Bereishis Rabbah) shows the continuation of Sarah's presence. The principle that the Land was given to the nations only temporarily, so that it would ultimately pass to Israel, is developed from the narrative itself. When the nations do not order themselves toward that purpose, their independent claim is nullified. This is not a doctrine of arbitrary exclusion. It is the structure of a covenant in which the particular people is the bearer of the universal purpose.

Covenantal Non-Domination: Orthodox Theology and Republican Theory

Here the Orthodox reading meets the concerns of republican political theory. Philip Pettit has argued that freedom is best understood as non-domination—the absence of arbitrary power—rather than mere non-interference (*Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government*, Oxford University Press, 1997). Quentin Skinner has recovered the classical republican insistence that liberty requires the absence of dependence on the will of another (*Liberty Before Liberalism*, Cambridge University Press, 1998). Both thinkers are concerned with the conditions under which power remains accountable and non-arbitrary. Daniel J. Elazar's work on covenantal political tradition and Eric Nelson's *The Hebrew Republic* (Harvard University Press, 2010) show how biblical and rabbinic sources shaped early modern republican thought, including the idea of republican exclusivism.

The covenantal tradition contributes a further dimension: the recognition that power is exercised within a framework of transcendent obligation and particular inheritance. Sarah's *serarah* is the refusal to allow the inheritance of the Land and the line of the covenant to become subject to an open-ended claim that would leave it dependent on the shifting will of other lineages. The exclusive transmission to Yitzchak is not domination of the other; it is the securing of a non-dominated inheritance for the people through whom the covenant is to be carried. Avraham's expansive chesed remains the outreach; Sarah's focused insistence remains the guard against the dissolution of the particular into the universal in a way that would leave the covenant without a concrete bearer.

Contemporary claims on Me'arat HaMachpelah illustrate the point with unusual clarity. The cave was purchased for Sarah's burial. The textual record emphasizes that Yishmael is the son of Sarah's maidservant, not the heir of Avraham and Sarah. The practical hora'ah at the close of the sicha is that when claims are advanced on the basis of Yishmael's descent, the answer is the textual and narrative fact of the exclusive inheritance. This is not a denial of the existence or the dignity of other peoples. It is the insistence that the particular inheritance secured by Sarah's work is not subject to an arbitrary redefinition. In republican terms, it is the refusal of domination: the refusal to allow the concrete possession of the Land and the burial place of the matriarch to be left dependent on a claim that the Torah itself has already ordered otherwise.

Differing Approaches and Critical Engagement

Different approaches exist within the tradition itself. Some readings emphasize the spiritual dimension of Sarah as the body that the soul must heed, drawing on the Zohar's mapping in other sichos (e.g., Likkutei Sichos Vol. 1). Others stress the legal and narrative fact of the exclusive inheritance. The Rebbe's reading in Volume 15 holds both: the events after death are the continuation of the particular life, and that particular life is the securing of an inheritance that is not subject to open-ended claims. Academic treatments of the Hebrew political tradition as a source for republican exclusivism (Nelson) can be placed in conversation with this reading without being reduced to it. The Torah's account is not a theory of property in the modern sense, nor is it a theory of republican government. It is a narrative of covenant in which the particular people is constituted by a focused transmission. The republican concern with non-domination finds a parallel, not an identity, in the insistence that the inheritance remain non-dependent on arbitrary redefinition.

Pure universalism risks dissolving the particular bearer of the covenant. Pure particularism risks forgetting the expansive chesed that Avraham embodies. The sicha holds the tension: the universal remains real; the particular is the channel.

Practical Hora'ah and Contemporary Resonance

The practical implication is straightforward. The name of the parsha is the key. *Chayei Sarah* names not only the years of the matriarch's life but the enduring influence that continues in the securing of the cave, the marriage of Yitzchak, and the exclusive inheritance. That influence is the particular *serarah* that guards the covenant against dissolution. It is the refusal of a domination that would leave the concrete possession of the Land and the line of transmission subject to claims the Torah has already ordered otherwise. Avraham opens the circle. Sarah keeps it from becoming formless. The events after her death show that the keeping continues. The life named by the parsha is therefore not exhausted by the day of her death. It is the life that is still being lived in the particular inheritance of the people through whom the covenant is carried.

Ongoing public discussion of ownership claims at the Cave of the Patriarchs underscores the continuing relevance of the hora'ah: state the truth of the exclusive inheritance clearly.

Extended Bibliography with Hyperlinks

- Likkutei Sichos, Volume 15, Chayei Sarah A (Kehot; English selections available).
- Rashi on Bereishis 23:1 and 21:12.
- Bereishis Rabbah 58:1.
- Bereishis 17:5; 21:10–12; 23; 24:67; 25:5–6, 9, 12.
- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (Oxford University Press, 1997).
- Quentin Skinner, *Liberty Before Liberalism* (Cambridge University Press, 1998).
- Eric Nelson, *The Hebrew Republic: Jewish Sources and the Transformation of European Political Thought* (Harvard University Press, 2010).
- Daniel J. Elazar, covenantal political tradition writings.
- Class notes and discussion, 4 November 2026, Beit Chabad Katamon-Resco.

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